

## LOK ADALATS



PANKAJ TIWARI

# Justice LEAGUE

**FAST AND LEGAL:** Lok Adalats in Bhopal are helping clear the pile of cases

Lok Adalats cut through the labyrinthine legal tangle, resolving domestic wrangles and property problems, without making petitioners wait for an eternity

■ By Ambreesh Mishra

**T**he well-heeled who can pay a fat fee opt for the brightest legal minds to solve their courtroom tangles. It's the *aam aadmi* who chooses low-cost options like Lok Adalats. Not anymore. In January 2007, one of the richest Bhopal families quietly settled a property dispute through a Lok Adalat. Devoid of the hustle-bustle of routine courts, these adalats are helping unclog the burdened judicial system. In the first 10 months of 2007, Lok Adalats in Bhopal, meeting twice a month, disposed of over 20,000 cases. In 2004, more than 2,00,000 Lok Adalats across India disposed of more than 16 million cases. The secret of fast work is the absence of argumentative lawyers and since cases are settled with mutual consent there is no further appeal.

Recently, H.S. Khan, of a leading business family of Bhopal, settled an

11-year-old dispute involving a Rs 44-crore property through Lok Adalat. Also, the family of 48-year-old Balkrishna Sharma, a Bank of Maharashtra employee who had died in a road accident, got a Rs 22-lakh claim from an insurance company because of the intervention of such an adalat. The

concept of Lok Adalats has evolved from the Legal Services Authorities Act, 1987. Under it, district authorities hold Lok Adalats to settle many cases, including criminal ones. Most cases are claims under the Motor Vehicles Act, or for bounced cheques under the Negotiable Instruments Act, apart from electricity theft under the Electricity Act 2002.

With high courts now powering the legal literacy drive with gusto, Lok Adalats could soon evolve into a mainstream forum for settling disputes quickly and effectively. ■

**1987**

saw Lok Adalats coming into being with the passing of the Legal Services Authorities Act

**6.7**

million people have benefited from the legal aid and advice of Lok Adalats in India in 2004